

transform short-term vote catching subterfuges into long-term strategems that would help in establishing a society bound by trust and respect, rather than bleeding it through caste and communal divides.

KARAN KHARB, *Noida*

I was surprised to see that a magazine of a stature like INDIA TODAY did not question Mayawati about the issues that dominate Indian polity today. We would have liked to know more about her thoughts than the colour of her salwar kameez and the glow on her face.

BALASUBRAMANIAN
ANGANATHAN, *on e-mail*

There is no doubt that Mayawati is a "hard working girl", but she should look at Sonia Gandhi, who is more laborious and has more liabilities, and learn from her. She cannot call herself to be a claimant for the post of the prime minister.

FAHEEM AHAMED, *Mumbai*

Crucial Contest

Though the battle for Karnataka is crucial for all the parties—Congress, BJP and JD(s)—active in the state, BSP's entry may well queer the pitch for the Big Three ("Battle of Wills", January 21). The Congress though would be affected more than the others. An alliance with JD(s) may be the solution for its problem.

A. JACOB SAHAYAM,
Thiruvananthapuram

Stained with Blood

The cover story, though informative, did not highlight one point—that of the bloodshed which these

confrontations led to ("The Year of Confrontation", January 14). It would have been better to christen the year as the Year of Bloodshed.

GANESHAN P., *Visakhapatnam*

The cover page of the magazine shows two rulers confronting each other. In old days, the rulers fought for the upliftment of their people. Today, however, the scenario has changed. The rulers are the sole benefi-

aries of such confrontations, while the people are their victims.

SUNITHA SASI, *Kochi*

Correction

I was surprised to see my attributes having been published under my father's name ("In Memoriam", January 14). Do allow me some more years before you publish my obituary.

VINAY BHARAT-RAM, *Delhi*

The error is regretted.

EDITOR

NO LONGER A GENTLEMAN'S GAME



Nobody has ever charged the Indian cricket team with racism—not even coloured cricketers from West Indies or South Africa ("Cricket's Biggest Crisis", January 21). To accept Harbhajan Singh's racism conviction or even settle for a lesser sentence would be a loss of face.

J. SESHAGIRI, *Mysore*

It is an undeniable truth that the index finger is the most destructive weapon today. It could belong either to a trigger-happy terrorist or an umpire.

RAJNEESH BATRA, *Delhi*

What is unacceptable is the manner in which Ponting and his men chose to blow out of proportion a matter that should have been settled on the field. That even the umpires chipped in to snatch the match from India, has made the loss only more bitter.

J. AKSHAY, *Secunderabad*

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Years Ago in India Today

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In Defence of a Father

Benazir will be 25 in June. As her father faces trial on varied charges, Benazir has changed radically, like everything in her country. Eldest in a family of four, she has a passion for politics born out of sheer desperation. Excerpts:

On the arrest of her father: He was arrested because they wanted to pretend that they had come to bring back democracy.



On the 1976 elections: The election was free and fair, but in certain localities, rigging did take place on both sides.

On the "witch-hunt": Have you ever heard of a case where the accused says he has no confidence in the judge and the judge continues to sit in judgement on him?

On the number of PPP workers in jail: Today, at least 50,000 PPP workers have been to jail.

—Sunil Sethi